

Q What should I look for in a birth partner?

Ideally the person you have by your side during labor and birth will be incredibly patient, cool under pressure, and extremely caring. Here's a list of the qualities your perfect birth partner would possess:

» **A sense of calm:** a natural ability to stop you from getting worried or stressed.

» **Confidence:** to support your wishes and to support your medical team if they offer advice that will speed your birth and is in the interests of the best health for you and your baby, even if that's at odds with your birth plan.

» **Being able to respond:** and take comments or wishes from you without judging them—or taking offence.

» **Reasonable lack of squeamishness:** at the sight of blood or vomit.

» **Empathy:** someone who can respond to your mood without even being asked to, and in the right way.

» **A firm respect for medical care:** knowing when to step aside to let the medical team work with you unimpeded and unchallenged.

» **Someone without any time restrictions:** a person who can give you all of his or her attention, unselfishly and unequivocally throughout your labor, however long it may take.

» **Someone who will talk through any decisions:** while you're in labor, he or she can give you sensible, sound advice with the interests of you and your baby in mind.



Back massage Your birth partner should be willing and able to give you a gentle massage during the early stages of labor. You can practice together before labor begins.

Q What is a doula and how can they help with my labor and birth?

From the Greek word for “caregiver,” a doula is a birthing companion whom you choose to help prepare you for labor and birth, stay with you throughout birth, and, sometimes, help after the birth. This can be in practical ways (with household chores, for example) and by giving advice on baby care and breast-feeding. Some doulas offer only prenatal care and birth support, and others specialize in postpartum care. Some will do both. Research in the UK suggests that C-section rates fall by as much as 50 percent for women who have a doula as a birth partner, and that labor may be up to two hours shorter. If you employ a doula as a birth partner, she can also support your partner if you wish—talking him through what's happening, reassuring him, and guiding him on how best to help you.

Q Will I still need a doctor if I have a doula?

Yes, since doulas work alongside doctors and do not replace a doctor's role, but rather provide extra support and continuity of care. A doula isn't necessarily medically trained, though she will have completed a doula course that means she can support pregnancy in safe, medically recognized ways. If you want to use a doula, you will need to hire one privately. Look for a doula who has a qualification that is accredited by the governing body in your country (such as DONA International).

Today more **fathers** than ever attend the births of **their babies**. However, a close family member or friend, a **private midwife**, or a **doula** are also all good choices to **support** you, or both you and your partner through **labor and birth**.